

BOOK REVIEWS

T. C. Winebrenner, Editor

van Eemeren, Frans and Rob Grotendorst and Francisca Snoeck Henkemans. *Argumentation: Analysis, Evaluation, Presentation*. Mahwah, NJ: Lawrence Erlbaum Associates, 2002. 195 pages. \$27.50 paper. ISBN 0805839526.

Selecting undergraduate textbooks is never an easy practice, especially in courses such as argumentation where fundamentally distinct assumptions about the nature of the material strongly influence the desirability of possible texts. *Argumentation: Analysis, Evaluation, Presentation* provides an interesting option for those instructors interested in offering a study of argument that grounds its analysis primarily in the exercise of argument as contrasting opinions. The text proceeds from the premise that difference in opinions can be understood as a basic building block for the study of argumentation.

The text grounds its approach in the philosophy that students may enjoy an easier transition to the study of argument by beginning with their experiences and the dynamics they encounter in developing and responding to varying opinions. The text's title previews the primary organization of material into discussions of analysis, evaluation and presentation. The analysis section defines the scope of its examination of argumentation, provides an introduction to the explicit and implicit elements of arguments. This section also explores structural means and a model of critical discussion as means of understanding these perspectives. The evaluation section provides a well-organized discussion of basic requirements of sound arguments and common fallacies. The final section, presentation, explores how to apply these standards of well-developed argumentation into both written and oral form.

Argumentation offers instructors a well-organized teaching tool. The chapters provide clear divisions and highlight particularly important concepts. Each chapter also includes useful recommendations for further reading as well as interesting exercises that can allow students to further their ability to become comfortable with the material. In later chapters, the inclusion of selected texts also enhances the instructor's ability to explore the subject matter.

The decision to ground this analysis in contrasting opinions provides the text's numerous strengths, and depending on the perspective of the instructor, potential limitations. The explicit focus on the dimensions of interpersonal communication allows the authors to embrace concepts like standpoints to demonstrate the importance of explicit and implicit elements of individual arguments. This perspective also provides a streamlined means of exploring the typically unwieldy subject of fallacies. Operating from an assessment of argumentative soundness, *Argumentation* examines ten rules that provide both more user-friendly means of defining these fallacies as well as a conceptual framework that builds upon those earlier models. The means of exploring the relevancy of certain premises or claims, for example, returns to the relationship between individual standpoints and their respective opinions. This conceptual clarity offers a useful means of introducing students to standards that assess argumentative quality.

Grounding the difference of opinion as primarily a matter of individual action provides an accessible means of introducing argumentation to new audiences. However, the near exclusive focus on individual argumentation also limits the ability of instructors to explore settings in which argumentation functions as part of larger and more formal, social dynamics. Although the individual lessons themselves do not preclude the possibility of social groups expressing differing opinions or possessing a variety of standpoints, the text does not provide theoretical or practical foundation to bridge this important perspective.

This is not the first text to ground the study of argumentation in a nonpolitical context that emphasizes informal means of competing claims, but because textbooks provide such an important organizational tool for the course, it is important that instructors consider which approaches will require additional efforts. *Argumentation*'s framework does not emphasize three prominent elements of argumentation studies: narrative, debate, and audience. A rhetorical focus on the commonality of narrative strategies, employing the works of Walter Fisher, often provides a means of examining the formation of individual perspectives and themes that resonate across larger social systems. The primary focus on individual perspective requires instructors to make substantial contributions to link these efforts to such common topics as the study of metaphors in public discourse.

This perspective may also hamper the ability of instructors to use debate as a means for evaluating opinions. Although formal means of debating are but one means to allow students to employ argumentative strategies, they do offer a way to reflect the importance of rules and structure that occur in a larger number of communicative settings. Without this

formal application it can become more difficult for students to appreciate these parameters. The model of critical discussion included in Chapter Two “Argumentation and Discussion” could serve as a potential gateway to this sense of formality, but the section emphasizes stages (or evolution) of arguments rather the influence of formal settings on the development of individual arguments. *Argumentation* reflects the importance of oral argumentation by including it within the presentation unit, but this chapter concentrates on the informal nature of developing a speech for a discussion. As currently designed, this section offers some useful suggestions for public discourse, but without a more formal means of considering public speaking, the broad goal of this chapter exceeds its actual contributions. Although the rigidity of debate may not appeal to all argumentative settings, it is a frequent means of exploring the specific importance of structure in many settings.

Finally, the decision to examine the bulk of the argumentative process from the perspective of the individual necessarily reduces the central position of audiences. By encouraging students to learn the means of argumentation from the perspective of a critic, they can be exposed to the work of Chaim Perelman, L. Olbrechts-Tyteca and other scholars who place a value on understanding the role audiences play in the formation and evaluation of propositions. The emphasis on dissenting opinions may, at times, replace a view of argumentation from someone other than a participant in the discussion.

The decision to emphasize the invention and development of opinions provides a frame that could be understood as consistent with narrative theory, models of debating, or audience analysis, but this step is not taken. In many ways, the decision to focus on argumentation as a conflict between opinions dissociates a prominent means of using argument theory to evaluate claims and warrants in overtly political contexts. This perspective offers students a language to assess the validity of reasoning, but it does so without substantial employment of many prominent perspectives.

The profound contributions that the authors have made to the field of argumentation reinforce the importance of the perspectives developed by *Argumentation*. The text is a very well developed means of introducing students to the study of argumentation. The limitations suggested in this review are preferences that individual instructors may or may not share. For those seeking a text that can be used to help examine argumentation as a means of political communication or as introduction to debate, the work is not designed to serve those purposes. If, however, instructors are interested in a single volume that can

introduce a range of concepts to students with no experience in this area, *Argumentation: Analysis, Evaluation, Presentation* provides a very compelling option.

Gordon Stables
University of Southern California

Copyright of Contemporary Argumentation & Debate is the property of Contemporary Argumentation & Debate and its content may not be copied or emailed to multiple sites or posted to a listserv without the copyright holder's express written permission. However, users may print, download, or email articles for individual use.